

Case Study: The Addison on 4th

Address: 308 4th Ave S, Seattle, WA 98104

Category: Fire Safety, Habitability, Elevator Negligence, Regulatory Failure

Timeframe: 2016–2025

Owner/Operator: Addison Partners LLC

Notable Lawsuit: Addison Partners LLC v. City of Seattle (2024)

I. Overview

The Addison on 4th represents one of the most egregious examples of institutional neglect, regulatory failure, and life-threatening housing conditions in Seattle's recent history. Over a span of years, city agencies allowed dangerous safety issues to persist, culminating in a fire on January 7, 2020 that endangered both tenants and first responders. Despite years of complaints, elevator rescues, and code violations, SDCI failed to enforce meaningful accountability. The property owner—who later sued the City claiming financial hardship from affordable housing regulations—was repeatedly prioritized over tenant safety.

II. Timeline of Events

2016–2019:

- Dozens of tenant complaints filed about broken elevators, pest infestations, heating outages, and chronic trash accumulation.
- Seattle Fire Department (SFD) logs 133 elevator rescues at the building within six years.

November 6, 2019:

- SFD notifies SDCI of severe fire safety issues at the Addison, citing trash blocking exits and egress concerns.

December 5, 2019:

- SDCI finally inspects the property—nearly a month after the SFD alert.
- A computer-generated pre-NOV is entered.

December 13, 2019:

- A formal Notice of Violation (NOV) is issued with a compliance deadline of January 13, 2020.

January 7, 2020:

- A fire breaks out at the Addison.
- Emergency response is complicated by previously cited issues (e.g., blocked exits).
- Multiple tenants displaced, and significant property damage occurs.

Post-Fire:

- Complaints and violations disappear from the public complaint database.

- Inspector "Steven" is shown closing cases without recorded follow-up.
- SDCI does not pursue financial penalties or public accountability.

2024:

- The building owner, Addison Partners LLC, files a lawsuit against the City of Seattle, claiming that local affordable housing regulations have caused them economic harm.
- This legal action comes despite their chronic noncompliance and failure to maintain basic safety standards for tenants.

III. Regulatory Failures by SDCI

1. Delayed Inspection Response:

2. SDCI waited nearly a month to respond to SFD's urgent fire safety warning.

3. Non-Enforcement of NOV:

4. NOV issued December 13, 2019 was never enforced before the fire broke out.

5. Complaint Suppression and Data Manipulation:

6. After the fire, related complaints were closed without documentation and later disappeared from public portals.

7. Neglect of Elevator Hazards:

8. Despite over 130 elevator rescues, no permanent fix or oversight was imposed.

9. No Fines or Penalties:

10. The property owner was never fined for multiple years of life-safety violations.

11. Public Safety Risk:

12. SFD personnel were endangered and diverted from other emergencies due to preventable Addison incidents.

IV. Tenant Impact

- Multiple tenants displaced by the fire.
- Disabled residents were particularly vulnerable due to repeated elevator failures.
- Residents lived amid trash, fire hazards, pest infestations, and unsafe conditions for years.
- Loss of trust in public safety agencies.

V. Owner Lawsuit Against the City (2024)

Addison Partners LLC sued the City of Seattle, alleging that its affordable housing mandates made it financially unfeasible to operate in compliance. The lawsuit conveniently ignored the Addison's long history of habitability violations, fire risks, and tenant endangerment. This audacious legal maneuver—suing the city while being a chronic violator—demonstrates the imbalance of power when landlords are protected while tenants suffer.

STLCA Statement:

"When regulatory failure enables chronic violators to keep endangering tenants without consequence, and then those same violators sue the city for trying to protect affordability, it is clear that we are rewarding entitlement instead of enforcing accountability."

VI. Evidence Archive

- **Appendix G:** Verified Addison complaint dataset (2016–2025): [Download CSV](#)
 - Public records show dozens of tenant complaints, SFD alerts, and SDCI inspection delays.
 - PubliCola coverage of SDCI's ethical failures and internal conflicts of interest [\[113†source†L1-L60\]](#) .
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VII. STLCA Policy Recommendations

- **Immediate Independent Audit** of all complaint records at the Addison between 2016 and 2021.
 - **Mandatory Enforcement Escalation** protocol when SFD issues hazard alerts.
 - **Permanent Ban on Self-Certification** for RRIO compliance at properties with any fire-related NOV's.
 - **Civil Liability Tracker:** Publicly log any owner who sues the city while under investigation or repeat violation status.
 - **Data Integrity Safeguards:** Prohibit post-incident complaint deletion or suppression.
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VIII. Conclusion

The Addison on 4th case reveals a catastrophic chain of failures in Seattle's housing oversight. Despite multiple warnings, SDCI failed to act until it was too late. The city protected a negligent landlord who later turned around and sued the city. This is the precise environment STLCA was created to reform.

"We don't just need stronger policies—we need enforcement with teeth and a system that values human safety over landlord convenience. The Addison fire should have never happened."